TRAVEL EXPENDITURE

THE DAILY DRAIN

MOBILITY MAP

Where workers travelling to fixed workplaces spend the most and least on commuting

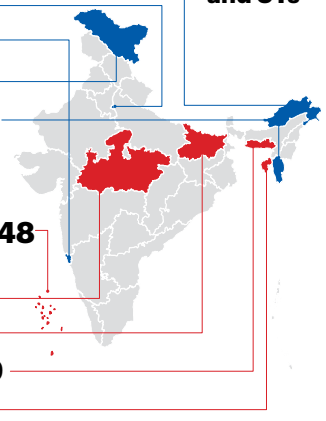
Source: National Household Travel Survey 2025-26

TOP 5

1. Arunachal Pradesh ₹**2,165**
2. Delhi ₹**2,038**
3. Goa ₹**1,874**
4. Ladakh ₹**1,531**
5. Mizoram ₹**1,507**

BOTTOM 5

1. Lakshadweep ₹**348**
2. Madhya Pradesh ₹**428**
3. Bihar ₹**469**
4. Meghalaya ₹**479**
5. Tripura ₹**506**





"The evidence says free ride schemes have a huge impact on women's savings, but not much on women's workforce participation. It's better to invest in bus infrastructure than making travel free"

— KARTHICK M.P., *Assistant Vice President and Strategy & Research Lead, The Udaiti Foundation*

THE SHORTCOMINGS

- **Rising commute expenses eat into already stretched household budgets**
- **Long journeys take a toll on family life, children's education and mental health**
- **Poor public transport connectivity limits access to jobs and opportunities**

THE SOLUTIONS

- **Expand affordable, reliable bus services to reduce dependence on personal vehicles**
- **Improve last-mile connectivity to make public transport a viable alternative**
- **Invest in adequate buses and terminals rather than relying on fare subsidies alone**

Shivanand Swamy, a senior mobility expert at CEPT University, Ahmedabad, says standards hold that someone making 48 or 50 trips a month should spend no more than 10 to 12 per cent of their budget on travel, and 15 per cent at most. With India's per capita incomes, he says, a large number of households are stretched beyond that. According to the latest India Human Development Survey, the urban monthly per capita income baseline is estimated at Rs 15,000, which means the urban spending on daily commutes is around 7 per cent. But experts like Swamy claim Rs 1,044 may not be an exhaustive estimate, as taxes, vehicle cost, maintenance and depreciation are not included in this calculation. Moreover, Indian surveys suffer from an inherent flaw of income-reporting bias, he adds.

Jagan Shah, a senior expert in urban development policy and practice, says: "Cost and distance decide which jobs a household can reach and this improves people's opportunities manifold."

The Time Cost

As many as 83 per cent of workers reach their workplace within 30 minutes, 79 per cent in cities, so about one in five urban workers takes longer. The average journey is 25 minutes. "At least 20 per cent of people travel more than 30 minutes. We only have 24 hours in a day. How much time are we willing to spare for travel?" asks Swamy. A Chennai study he cites puts the tolerable limit at 60 to 70 minutes a day. Beyond that, he says, excess travel time strains marriages, children's schooling and mental health. "Bengaluru, Mumbai, Delhi, we are already travelling in excess."

Smaller cities have brought down the average travel time in this study. But the way urban planning unfolds currently, says Swamy, the average travel time in the next survey might be much higher, not lower.

Beyond Free Rides

Swamy argues that public transport needs financing. Sweeping subsidies or free travel are not a comprehensive solution. It certainly does not absolve governments of the onus of developing reliable, safe and holistic mass public transportation with last-mile connectivity, operating in an ecosystem where pedestrians are prioritised. "Free transport has its social contribution, but it also has an adverse impact on the overall sustainability of public transport, because resources are not unlimited," he says. "When it is free, people tend to use it, but also abuse it."

Karthick M.P., assistant vice president and strategy & research lead at The Udaiti Foundation, which is focused on women's economic empowerment, says that governments have introduced free bus schemes for women in 13 states and Union Territories. "The evidence says free ride schemes have a huge impact on women's savings and household income, but no clear impact on women's workforce participation," he adds.

"Affordability and accessibility are the key for economic activity. Good public transport means higher productivity," Swamy says. "It matches people with better jobs, and entrepreneurs get better-skilled people. Mobility enables all that." ■